

There Is No “Get Rich Quick” Scheme

There are a few legitimate reasons for someone trying to get rich quickly, but more often than not, it's the result of impatience, fear, or plain old greed. Even if you're in a solid long-term plan that's working, it's easy to get distracted by a new opportunity or a friend's “sure thing” investment. Trust me, I've been down that road. Back in the late 1990s, a friend convinced me to put some money into AOL stock. Now, I've already told you how risky single stock is, but I went for it. I started with a few thousand dollars, and that doubled quickly. I added some more, and that doubled, too. I was betting on luck—but eventually, my luck ran out. I ended up losing about \$25,000 before I finally woke up and got off that roller coaster.

When it was all said and done, I was left scratching my head and wondering how I had gotten so distracted. That AOL mess pulled my attention—and my money—away from the slow and steady mutual fund investments I had been focused on. If I had put that \$25,000 into a good growth stock mutual fund instead of risking it on a get-rich-quick stock deal, I'd be \$168,000 richer right now. That \$25,000 would have grown to about \$1.1 million by the time I retire if I had just trusted the plan I was working on. But seeing my buddy's quick, easy returns got the best of me. I thought, *If he can do it, why can't I?*

Building wealth is a long-term play. That's the difference between the words *wealth* and *rich*, at least from my perspective. “Getting rich” just means falling into a pile of money. All the focus is on the cash, not the person. “Building wealth,” however, is about a patient, hardworking person's journey to millions. It's about the character they develop over many years of dedication and persistence. When you work for your wealth over years and decades, you'll usually find yourself with the character to manage it wisely. When you suddenly become rich overnight from a risky investment or a lottery ticket, *you* haven't changed at all; your bank account has. That means all that money is now at the mercy of your impatient, risky